

PRACTITIONER HANDBOOKS · B6

Retention, Retrieval and Migration

The owner-document for warning signs, early intervention, resignations and Rule 183, unattached Brethren, lessons learned and migration. Other documents cross-refer here.

Audience	Lodge Mentors, Personal Mentors and Lodge Officers
Issue	Issue 1a (Draft for Review), October 2026: the July 2026 text set on the Provincial template

1 Purpose and Principles

> *We do not retain members by design; we build a culture that prepares and supports them - retention follows naturally.* > > - Provincial Mentoring Framework

This guide covers the moments when that culture is tested: when a member's engagement fades, when a resignation letter arrives, when a Brother leaves, and when a member relocates. It brings into one place the warning signs, the intervention steps, the procedural rules and the hand-offs between officers, so that no member is lost for want of anyone knowing what to do - and no officer acts alone.

Four principles govern everything in it:

- **Retention is an outcome, not a target.** Nothing here is about numbers. It is about noticing, caring, and acting early.
- **Help, never interrogate.** The question is always “How can we help?” - never “Why aren't you attending?”

- **The pattern is the signal.** Risk shows as a break in an individual's own pattern, not as a low absolute level of attendance. A 'Knife and Fork' Mason who has always attended twice a year is content; a stalwart who stops coming is not.
- **Retrieval is a team activity.** Secretary, Treasurer, Personal Mentor, Lodge Mentor, Almoner, Worshipful Master and Province each hold a piece. This guide defines the hand-offs.

Evidence worth keeping in view: a significant proportion of losses occur within two years of Initiation, often before Raising; the year after the Chair is the second recognised risk window; and where exit conversations happen, roughly **one resignation in three is recovered**. Early action prevents resignations; late action rarely does.

2 Who Does What - Roles and Hand-offs

Role	Contribution
Lodge Secretary	Holds the attendance record and shares it with the Lodge Mentor and Almoner after each meeting. Receives any resignation - and acknowledges receipt only (see §5): the Secretary has no power to accept a resignation. Notifies the Almoner and the Provincial Office without delay.
Lodge Treasurer	Often the first to see hard evidence of disengagement: subscriptions falling into arrears. A quiet word to the Almoner or Lodge Mentor at the first missed subscription - long before any Rule 148/181 process - turns a bookkeeping fact into a mentoring opportunity.
Personal Mentor	The relationship. Notices change first, makes the informal contact (Step 1), stays close through any difficulty, and keeps the Lodge Mentor honestly informed.
Lodge Mentor	The co-ordinator. Monitors patterns across the Lodge, supports Personal Mentors, decides when a concern moves to Steps 2-4, keeps discreet records, and is the Lodge's link to the Provincial Mentoring Team.
Lodge Almoner	Leads on welfare - health, money, bereavement, family - and on contact with non-attenders and former members. Where a mentoring conversation uncovers a welfare need, the Almoner takes the lead and the mentoring record notes only 'referred to Almoner'.
Membership Officer	Holds the Lodge's membership picture - joiners and leavers over time - and works with the Lodge Mentor on patterns and on lessons learned (§6).

Worshipful Master	Owns Step 3 conversations and the Lodge culture that makes them rare. Ensures the Lodge Mentor's report is heard with the same weight as the Treasurer's.
Provincial Mentoring Team	Steps in where an impartial voice helps, where a member may thrive in a different Lodge, or where a pattern crosses Lodges. Contact via the Provincial Grand Mentor's office - in confidence, and always as a strength, never a failure.

One handover rule above all: every concern has a named owner at every moment. When a case passes from Personal Mentor to Lodge Mentor, or Lodge to Province, the pass is explicit - and the loop is closed: whoever acts confirms afterwards that the member actually feels better, not merely that something was done.

3 Warning Signs

The full reference version. (A one-page card exists for every mentor's pocket.) None of these signs alone is cause for alarm; a combination, or a persistent pattern, warrants action under §4.

Category	Signs
Attendance patterns	Two or more consecutive meetings missed without explanation • habitual late arrival or early departure • attending only Installations or social events • ceasing to visit other Lodges • absence over the summer break extending into autumn.
Participation changes	Reluctance to accept work or office • withdrawal from conversation and social interaction • missing LoI while holding office • lack of preparation where preparation was once a point of pride • distraction or visible unhappiness in meetings.
Communication indicators	Unanswered calls and messages • expressed frustration, disappointment or disillusionment • repeated mention of time or money pressures • unfavourable comparison of Freemasonry with other commitments • subscription arrears.

Timing intelligence. The first two years, the months after Raising, and the year after the Chair are the recognised risk windows - mentoring contact should intensify at each. National research also finds that candidates Initiated between January and June are less likely to remain than those Initiated between September and December, largely because the summer break interrupts their early participation: Lodges should plan deliberate summer contact and social touchpoints for spring Initiates.

Remember the stated reason is often not the real reason. 'Work pressure' may mean unsuitable meeting times, a personality clash, or simple lack of enjoyment. Only a relationship of trust surfaces the real reason - which is why the Personal Mentor, not a form, is the Province's early-warning system.

4 Early Intervention - the Four Steps

Graduated, warm, and mostly invisible. Most concerns are resolved at Step 1 and never look like a 'process' at all.

Step 1 - Personal Mentor: informal contact

- After any unexpected absence without apology: a friendly call or message. Purpose: welfare, help if needed, and to say he was missed - several Brethren asked after him.
- After two consecutive misses (with or without apology): contact within seven days of the second meeting, looking gently for underlying causes or emerging concerns.
- Tone is everything: the member's needs motivate the call, never any inconvenience to the Lodge.

Step 2 - Lodge Mentor involved

- Where concern persists or the cause needs more than friendship: the Lodge Mentor takes the overview, considers what the Lodge itself could change (timing, cost, culture, an office that does not fit), and keeps a discreet note.
- Close the loop: act on the cause, then confirm with the member that things actually feel better.

Step 3 - Worshipful Master's conversation

- Where the matter touches Lodge culture, office-holding, or relations with another member: a considered private conversation, with the Almoner alongside for anything touching welfare.

Step 4 - Provincial referral

- Where an impartial third party gives the best chance - or where the member might thrive in a different Lodge (a man unhappy in one Lodge is often happy in another; retrieval for the Craft matters more than retention in one Lodge).
- Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office. Referral is a sign of responsible mentoring, not failure.

5 When a Resignation Arrives

A resignation letter is the beginning of a conversation, not the end of one. The rules give the Lodge real time - use it.

The rules (Rule 183, Book of Constitutions)

- **The Secretary acknowledges receipt only.** He has no power to accept a resignation on the Lodge's behalf, and his reply must not read as acceptance.
- **Same-day notifications:** Almoner, Lodge Mentor and the Provincial Office are told without delay.
- **A written resignation** can be withdrawn in writing at any time before it is reported to the Lodge. Once reported, the Lodge may vote to invite withdrawal - and the member then has sixty days to withdraw it. The window was extended from 21 days precisely to give retrieval conversations time to work.
- **An oral resignation in open Lodge** is irrevocable unless the Lodge votes immediately to invite withdrawal. An emailed resignation takes effect from receipt, subject to signed written confirmation before the next regular meeting.
- **Offering reconsideration is the Lodge's choice -** but no harm is done by offering it, except where obviously inappropriate.

The retrieval conversation

Within the window, the best-placed person - Almoner, Personal Mentor, Lodge Mentor or sponsor - has an unhurried, private conversation. Its purpose is understanding, not persuasion:

- What has led to this? (Listen for the real reason behind the stated one.)
- Is there anything the Lodge could have done differently - or could still do?
- Would a change help: reduced involvement for a season, a leave of absence, stepping back from office, a transfer to a Lodge that better fits his circumstances or age profile?
- If the cause is money or health: the Almoner leads, and the Masonic Charitable Foundation may be able to help - resignation should never be the price of a hard year.
- If he is moving away: this is migration, not loss - see §7, and encourage him to remain a member until he has joined elsewhere.

If he still chooses to go, part with warmth and gratitude. Preserve the goodwill: how a Lodge handles a departure is watched by every member who stays - and it decides whether the door feels open for a return.

6 After a Loss - Keeping the Door Open and Learning the Lessons

Unattached Freemasons (Rule 127)

A Brother who resigns from all Lodges remains a Freemason, and this need not be a permanent loss. Circumstances change back. The rules he - and any Lodge inviting him - should know:

- He may attend any Lodge once as an unattached visitor (signing 'unattached' with his last Lodge's name and number).
- With a view to joining, he may attend one Lodge up to three times in twelve months, provided the Master confirms that purpose in writing to the Secretary.
- These rights do not extend to Brethren excluded or expelled, or who resigned from the Craft itself.

Keeping warm

- The Almoner keeps in touch: a birthday card, the Provincial newsletter, invitations to social functions and White Table evenings.
- He remains eligible for Masonic Charitable Foundation support - say so when he leaves; it matters.
- Some of the Craft's best returners were invited back by a Lodge that simply never stopped being friendly.

Lessons learned

- Resist the comfortable story ('he wasn't really right for us'). Collate the real reasons across several departures and look for patterns: timing, cost, culture, a particular period, a particular office.
- The Lodge Mentor and Membership Officer review losses together at least annually and feed what they learn into the Lodge's plans; several resignations in a short period warrant a fuller Lodge review.
- Themes - anonymised, never blaming - are shared with the Provincial Mentoring Team through the normal reporting rhythm, so the Province can act on what individual Lodges cannot see.

7 Migration - a Continuation of Mentoring

> *Migration is a continuation of mentoring, not an administrative exercise. > > -* Provincial Mentoring Framework

- **Identify early.** Mentors ask about house and job moves as a matter of course. The earlier a relocation is known, the better the chance the member continues in Freemasonry without a break.
- **Trigger the process.** Contact the Provincial Grand Mentor's office, which initiates the Member Migration Process with the destination Province - introductions, visits to candidate Lodges, and support until he is settled. (Hermes increasingly automates the cross-Provincial notification; verify the current process with the Provincial Office at the time.)
- **Keep him a member until he lands.** Encourage him to retain membership - or accept a courtesy arrangement - until he has joined his new Lodge, so his service is unbroken.
- **Stay in touch until settled.** The sending Lodge's mentoring duty ends not at the county boundary but when he is happily at home in his new Lodge - and every case is followed to a conclusion, successful or not.

8 Escalation, Confidentiality and Reporting

- **Escalate to the Province when:** a resignation risk needs impartial help; a welfare matter exceeds the Almoner's local means; a dispute is entangled with the concern; several members are affected at once; or a relocation triggers migration.
- **Confidentiality:** personal circumstances are shared only with those who need them, and welfare detail lives with the Almoner. Mentoring records note facts and actions, sparingly, per the Style, Terminology and Data Guide.
- **Reporting:** retention and retrieval experience flows through the normal rhythm - the monthly mentoring call, quarterly returns, and the annual report - as anonymised themes, never named cases, and never attributing blame.

Quick reference: the Warning Signs and Early Intervention card carries §§3-4 of this guide on a single page. The principles throughout are quoted from The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles (Tier A1).

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